

Wyoming Land Trust

Conservation Easement Information Packet

Prepared for: Charles McKay, McKay Ranch, 1462 County Road 6WX, Cody, Wyoming 82414.

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What a conservation easement is

A conservation easement is a voluntary, legal agreement that permanently limits certain uses of land in order to protect its conservation values. The landowner keeps ownership of the land and may continue agricultural use, while the easement prevents subdivision and most development in perpetuity.

What this would mean for the McKay Ranch

The agreement under discussion would cover the full property of approximately 2,800 acres, including the grassland, the Sage Creek bottom, and the timbered hills to the west. Agricultural use, grazing leases, and the existing water infrastructure would continue. Subdivision and commercial development would be permanently restricted.

Possible tax benefits

A donated easement may qualify as a charitable contribution for federal income tax purposes, and Wyoming offers property tax treatment that recognizes the reduced development value. The exact benefit depends on a qualified appraisal and the advice of your own tax preparer. The Land Trust does not provide tax advice.

Things to weigh carefully

- The restriction is permanent and runs with the land to future owners.
- Heirs keep the ability to ranch and lease, but lose the option to subdivide or sell for development.
- A qualified appraisal is required to establish value.
- The decision should be made with family and with independent legal and tax counsel.

Next step

A representative will meet with you at the ranch on October 3, 2026 to walk the property and answer questions. There is no obligation. No agreement is signed at that meeting. We encourage you to involve the family members who will one day hold this land.